must be allowed a reprieve from the death sentence; they are worried no end over the fearsome repercussions in the valley if Afzal, who hails from there, is put to death. The state unit of the Congress had obviously gone along with this view, and an impression was created to the effect that the Congress chief minister of the coalition regime in the state had spoken to the Union government requesting commutation of the death sentence.[2] The leaders of the Congress party in the state of Delhi have their own calculations to make; it is a Hindu-majority territory, and there is the danger of the BJP, with its jingoist stance in the matter, running away with the Hindu vote in the not-so-distant state Assembly polls. The Congress chief minister of Delhi has therefore lost little time to inform the Centre that she and her colleagues want Afzal to hang. Presumably because of party pressure at the national level, the Jammu and Kashmir chief minister has now backtracked somewhat: what he had earlier conveyed to the Centre, he has laboriously explained, was his personal opinion; he is in principle against the death penalty.[3] The Jammu and Kashmir chief minister hems and haws because Afzal hails from his state; the Delhi chief minister feels equally qualified to go on record on the issue since the crime was perpetrated in her state. But while the murders were committed within the Parliament complex, the conspiracy was supposedly hatched elsewhere. That apart, does not the Parliament of India belong to the entire country and was not the attack targeted against MPs coming from all over the country? Along with the government of Delhi, that of every other state too, it follows, ought to be asked to submit their views in the matter; the Union Cabinet, before rendering its advice to the President, must take into account this collective judgement.

In any event, should not the larger long-range interests of the nation be of prime consideration here? According to New Delhi’s own admission, incidents of violence are on the wane in the Valley; infiltrations across the border have also shrunk significantly in recent months. Cross-border travel has resumed, even though on a partial scale. The heads of government of the two countries met recently at Havana and pledged to set up a joint consultative machinery to resolve outstanding bilateral issues. By far the major such issue is that of Kashmir. One has only to recollect the upheaval that took place in the Valley when, more than a decade ago, another person accused of terrorist activities, Maqbool Butt, was hanged. Does the Government of India want a repeat of that gory season? What the fallout of such a turn of events would be on India’s defence and security expenditure